

Peak mentality: Sumit Antil reacts after a throw during the Paralympics 2024. GETTY IMAGES

revisit my basics and sort out my technique,” Sumit nodded.

The men’s javelin podium remained the same in the Paralympics in Tokyo and Paris.

Australia’s Michal Burian, who won silver three years ago, got a bronze in Paris, while Sri Lankan Dulan Kodithuwakku went from bronze in Tokyo to silver in Paris. Sumit’s place at the top did not change.

Sumit’s best effort of the night was 3.56m more than that of silver medalist Dulan. This margin was just a touch higher than Arshad Nadeem’s lead over Neeraj in the men’s javelin Olympic final a few weeks ago. Nadeem’s monstrous 92.97m throw caught the world by surprise, but Sumit’s lead was expected.

His effortless pursuit of bettering his own world record often feels like Armand Duplantis’, the Swedish-American pole vaulter who holds the top 10 best marks in his discipline. Sumit, too, has broken the world record at least eight times in the last five years, and despite bursts of brilliance from his competitors, no one has come close. While his opponents aim for the 70m mark, Sumit has long set his sights on clearing 80 metres.

Much like Duplantis, watching Sumit compete is watching one man compete against himself, but he doesn’t particularly enjoy hearing it.

“The aim is simple. If I am at 70m today, then tomorrow I need to get to 71, 72. But it would be unfair to say I am competing with myself because the others are also throwing well. The Sri Lankan athlete threw 67m — a new record in his category. The Australian athlete (bronze medallist Michal) has also been good. We can’t view anyone lightly. But we do focus on how to improve ourselves and our performance,” he explained.



With the major event of the year out of the way, Sumit now has clear priorities. Number one: fix his back and bring his core to peak fitness.

Number two: make up for the time spent away from family. Number three: open himself up to the world a bit more. “I am conscious of the kind of attention I get when I am competing. I know people have high expectations of me. But I’ve never felt the need to change or edit myself just because people now have an eye on what I do or say. I usually speak from the heart, positive or negative.

“The idea now is to be a bit more active on social media. I have content from my own journeys that could perhaps inspire people to get into sports and do what I am doing. Achievements are one thing, but I’d like to show people our day-to-day journeys and inspire them. I hope I can give some time to this alongside everything else I do,” he said.

The next big event on his radar is the World Championships next year, which India is hoping to host. The prospect of registering his next world record on home soil brings a little sparkle to Sumit’s eyes.

“My team and I view the event

calendar in small portions.

Immediately on my priority list is the World Championships next year. So the idea will be to perfect my body and technique as much as possible by then and give my best there.”

There’s also the chance of doing a three-peat at the Los Angeles Paralympics in 2028, and 26-year-old Sumit fancies his odds.

“As far as LA 2028 is concerned, I am 26 now. By then I’ll be 30. In our game, the peak age is around 31-32. It would be great to top the podium there too. The efforts will certainly be in that direction.”

With increasing attention on para-sports, and support from the government and private sponsors flowing in for para-athletes, Sumit expects the spotlight to increase.

“I feel an athlete who doesn’t feel pressure is either not taking the game seriously or is on another level of legend in their sporting arc. In my case, I did feel a lot of pressure. There was the pressure to maintain my position at this level and meet people’s expectations. Staying consistent is the hardest part — it’s easy to reach the top, but remaining there is the biggest challenge.”